Proposal for the Massachusetts Daily Collegian to attend the College Media Association's Spring National College Media Convention 2026

December 15, 2025

Submitted by Kalana Amarasekara
On behalf of the Massachusetts Daily Collegian

Kalana Amarasekara, Assistant Arts Editor, Massachusetts Daily Collegian
kamarasekara@umass.edu | 301-538-9107

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Sophie Williamson, Director of Administration and Finance
Journalism Department, College of Social and Behavioral Sciences
University of Massachusetts Amherst
300 Massachusetts Ave
Amherst, MA 01003

Dear Ms. Williamson,

I am excited to present to you this grant proposal for three members of the Massachusetts Daily Collegian, the University of Massachusetts Amherst's student-run newspaper, to attend the College Media Association's Spring National College Media Convention in New York City, from March 4 to March 7, 2026. The purpose of my proposal is to demonstrate how having representatives from the Collegian attend the Convention will benefit the newspaper, and the University as a whole, by allowing them to take fresh perspectives from seasoned journalists from across the country and become better equipped to inform the University whilst honing their own reporting skills. To achieve this goal, we would need a grant of $2,287 to pay the registration fees to attend the Convention, transportation costs from Amherst to New York City, and hotel accommodation for our stay in New York City.

Having been a member of the Massachusetts Daily Collegian for over two years, I have seen firsthand the efforts that my colleagues and I have undertaken to keep the University, and by extension the wider Amherst community, informed on current events that pertain to us. The members of the Massachusetts Daily Collegian have shown great professionalism in reporting on a variety of key events, from covering the 2024 presidential election in an unbiased manner with consistent and thorough updates, to keeping Amherst residents updated about the fire that destroyed the Olympia Place housing complex in November 2025, leaving several residents - many of them University students - displaced and without basic necessities for their day-to-day lives. The many facilitators of the Spring National College Media Convention are experienced journalists with fresh perspectives, and they can present the same journalistic skills that our editors and writers at the Collegian utilize from different perspectives, using their own professional experiences. By listening to these incredibly skilled reporters present these fresh perspectives at the Convention, the Collegian's already accomplished journalists will have the opportunity to develop their journalistic skills even further, therefore developing newfound ways of reporting the news and keeping our community engaged.

The Collegian largely obtains the funding for its facilities, including travel, through donations; to attend the event, a guaranteed sum of $2,287 is necessary for our registration to attend the Convention, our travel to and from New York, our accommodation whilst in the city.

Should you have any further questions about this grant proposal, please do not hesitate to contact me at my email address, kamarasekara@umass.edu, or my phone number, 301-538-9107.

Thank you very much for your time and consideration,

Kalana Amarasekara

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Statement of Necessity

The Massachusetts Daily Collegian is the independent, student-run, non-profit newspaper for the University of Massachusetts Amherst. Having been an integral part of the University since 1890, it has developed from a regular print newspaper into a daily, web-based publication, best suiting the needs of many students at present. It serves not only the University's vast student body but also the residents of the wider Amherst community by keeping them current on events pertaining to the local community's wellbeing. By adhering to the Society of Professional Journalists' Code of Ethics (Massachusetts Daily Collegian, "Statement of Independence"), its unwavering commitment to maintaining high standards in reporting information is evident in the many topics it has covered.

The Collegian has discussed the presidential election of 2024, presenting key election information in an objective, straightforward manner and providing consistent updates as the election progressed and ultimately ended ("'Sometimes the fight takes a while': Vice President Kamala Harris formally concedes"), whilst also giving voice to community advocates and people who may have been affected by potential election outcomes ("The 2024 Election Special Issue").

In November of 2025, when a fire in the Olympia Place apartment complex broke out, the Collegian's News team attended the scene to obtain updates about the fire ("Breaking: Massive fire devastates Olympia Place"), determined who was affected and discussed efforts to help those impacted by the fire ("The aftermath of the Olympia fire: community rallies in support of victims"). Though the fire caused no fatalities, Olympia Place housed many students at the University of Massachusetts, who lost their accommodation and their personal property as

a result of the fire. By covering the fire with utmost timeliness and objectivity, the Collegian established itself as a reliable media outlet that did not merely deliver news, but also captured the ramifications of the fire on our community, thus boosting engagement within and beyond the town of Amherst.

As a non-profit publication, we rely largely on community donors to fund our programs; thus, we do not have a high amount of funding for the means to assert our status as an independent publication, including by printing magazines, producing advertising material and traveling to conferences. Further, as a student newspaper, we do not have a high amount of traction compared to most major publications. Although we report information through various means, including on our website and social media accounts, the community support we hope to garner is not always high.

This problem is not unique to the Collegian. With a dearth of local news organizations at present, student-run publications frequently find themselves issues concerning the entire area their universities serve ("How student reporters are helping rebuild local news"). Additionally, with the Corporation for Public Broadcasting about to close after losing funding ("Corporation for Public Broadcasting to shut down after being defunded by Congress, targeted by Trump"), student media outlets have voluntarily taken on the responsibility of informing their communities. Despite the increase in responsibility, the limited amount of support available to student newspapers currently remains a key issue ("How student reporters are helping rebuild local news"). The Convention is a timely event where student journalists can learn to hone their rights, and thus, the Collegian's attendance at the event is necessary at present.

At the Collegian, while we apply and practice key journalistic principles in our day-to-day work, we do not always have the direct support of other media specialists who apply the

same principles as we do, but have even more lived experiences in the fields of journalism, whether reporting itself, fact-checking, editing or media law. Consulting and obtaining guidance from experienced journalists and other media professionals, many of whom have continued their journalistic careers beyond their student newspapers at university, will allow us to demonstrate our independence as a reliable news publication that serves the community. By attending the Spring National College Media Convention in March, we will be able to obtain further guidance in developing our reputation as an independent news outlet.

Statement of Request

To continue training our journalists to maintain the Collegian's credibility as an independent student newspaper, it is necessary that we obtain the support of the College Media Association by attending the Spring National College Media Convention. We request the Journalism Department for a sum of $2,287 for our representatives to pay the Convention's registration fees, travel to New York by train and find accommodation during our stay.

The Spring National College Media Convention, which will be held from Wednesday, March 4, 2026 to Saturday, March 7, 2026, is organized by the College Media Association ("RTDNA @ CMA: Spring National College Media Convention"); it will be held at the New York Marriott Marquis hotel in New York City, where we hope to stay during the Convention. The College Media Association is a key stakeholder in advocating for the rights of student journalists, actively recognizing them as integral figures in the media and assisting them in disseminating information by way of "news publications, broadcast and radio stations, podcasts, literary and feature magazines, and yearbooks" whilst also offering training and education programs in journalistic skills that student journalists can apply, both at university and beyond

(“Home | College Media Association”). To obtain the support of the College Media Association at the Convention, it is important that we obtain the means to travel to New York City.

The College Media Association also hosted MediaFest ‘25 from Oct. 15 to Oct. 18, 2025, in Washington, DC; three representatives from the Massachusetts Daily Collegian had the privilege of attending that particular conference. There, discussions and training sessions on various elements of journalistic independence were hosted by various specialists in media and media law, including an editing workshop conducted by an editor at Pew Research Center, one of the United States’ most credible think tanks, and a discussion on covering protests and other turbulent events led by a representative of the James W. Foley Foundation, an advocacy group representing American citizens in current hostage situations (“Media Fest”). These talks presented new perspectives for student-run publications to consider, giving them solid ground for them to establish their independence as news organizations.

Attending the Spring National College Media Convention as well will give the Collegian a solid reputation as a publication that consistently seeks to build upon itself and give its personnel opportunities to practice their journalistic independence. Thus, if we obtain the grant to travel to New York and stay at the New York Marriott Marquis, the long-term benefits to the Collegian will allow us to maintain our independence and serve our community long after the Convention has finished.

Description of Short-term and Long-term Proposals for Attendance

Short-term proposals

Our short-term goals of attending the Spring National College Media Convention are to obtain the immediate support of the College Media Association and the various facilitators of the Convention, who can use their expertise and perspectives of working in the media to guide us in the long term. Three representatives of the Collegian will attend the Convention and share their experiences upon their return to the University. Our short-term goals of attending the Convention include, but are not limited to the following:

- Attending the talks and workshops hosted by the presenters at the Convention
- Networking with media professionals and fellow student journalists who are presenting at/facilitating/attending the Convention

Long-term proposals

Each of the above short-term proposals we have for attending the Spring National College Media Convention are connected to our long-term proposals as well, which we hope to apply continuously beyond our return from the Convention.

Attending talks and workshops at the Convention

The workshops hosted by the presenters of the Convention are on topics that members of the Collegian may not have considered writing about before. At MediaFest '25, which was also hosted by the College Media Association in October 2025, Laura Moorhead, a professor of journalism at San Francisco State University who used to work as a reporter for the San Francisco Times, delivered a talk on how to report on homelessness and poverty. She covered

the issues that factored into housing insecurity in college, including racial barriers and substance addiction, and described how housing insecurity was an issue that affected college students as well, making it relevant to the student attendees as well ("Media Fest"). Although the exact agenda of the Spring National College Media Convention is not known as of Dec. 15, 2025, we are certain that there will be talks that offer fresh perspectives to our student journalists, which they can utilize whilst working for the Collegian and beyond.

Making use of networking opportunities at the Convention

The networking opportunities at the Convention, with journalists and media professionals from all walks of life and all stages in their journalistic careers, will be invaluable. Student journalists nationwide will be attending the Convention. They will have their own experiences from serving different communities, which will likely have different cultures to the culture of Massachusetts. Also attending will be student media advisers, who are likely to have direct experience in helping student journalists establish their independence as future media professionals. Through networking, the representatives of the Collegian will form meaningful professional connections with fellow students and media advisers alike, which will open new avenues for students and give them ideas for what topics to cover for the Collegian. Furthermore, the various speakers and workshop organizers will come from diverse backgrounds and approach the field of journalism from a variety of perspectives. Some will focus on editing, and high editing standards are vital for the credibility of a student newspaper. Some will focus on media law, and it is key for journalists, including student journalists, to know their rights as independent vehicles for information. The representatives of the Collegian can also form

networks with these guest speakers, use them as future references in job applications, and apply the lessons they have learned from those talks to their journalism.

Description of Measure of Proposed Success

Attending the Spring National College Media Convention will prove successful to the Massachusetts Daily Collegian; not just to the members who attend the Convention, but to the entire newspaper as a whole. People who attend will develop the newfound knowledge they learn at the Convention, and transfer that knowledge to those who have not attended. That knowledge transfer will allow us to take on innovative article ideas and raise awareness of the local community, and streamline our editing processes so that all editors involved in producing articles can agree on whether it is suitable for publication or not.

Proposed Success for the Collegian as a Whole

By utilizing key points learned through the training sessions and networking opportunities at the Spring National College Media Convention, the Collegian will take steps to increase its editorial, production and reporting standards. We will broaden the scope of topics for articles, enabling innovative article ideas that foster community engagement to be brought to fruition. We will continue to raise the standards of editing articles within the Collegian, easing the internal editing processes for all editors involved. We will carry the above measures out over a set period of time so that they can be implemented quickly and effectively.

Increasing the scope of topics for articles

- The Collegian will hold the monthly Board of Editors meeting on Sunday, March 8, 2026, the day after the representatives return from the Convention. With input from its

Editor-In-Chief, Managing Editor, the Head Editors of the four main editorial sections - News, Sports, Arts and Opinion - and the Assistant Editors from all four sections, the representatives will present the knowledge they obtained from attending the Convention.

- At the meeting, the editors will list ideas for articles for all four sections and allocate writers for each article. Story ideas include, but are not limited to:
    - Reporting on homelessness in Amherst - ideal for the News section
    - Reporting on lack of funding for college newspapers - ideal for either the News or the Opinion section, depending on how the writer wants to approach the topic
    - Reporting on creative student initiatives - ideal for the Arts section
    - Reporting on student athletes and how they balance their sports careers with their academic careers - ideal for either the News or the Sports section
- Head section editors will hold writers accountable for finishing each of their articles, which they will complete by May 2026, before the end of the semester.
- The articles will increase community engagement both within and outside Amherst, raising awareness of these issues that the Collegian may not have otherwise covered

Raising the standards of editing processes

- Currently, the Collegian's articles are edited by three people before they are published. An Assistant Editor from the article's section will do the bulk of the edits; a Copy Editor (usually an Assistant or Head Editor of any section) will edit for grammar, spelling and mechanics; a Night Editor (usually the Editor-In-Chief, Managing Editor or Head Editor of any section) will reevaluate the article and determine whether it is suitable for publication on the website.

- As Copy and Night editors often work in different sections, there have been occasions in the past where the suitability of an article for publication has been debated among editors during the editing process, which has delayed the publication of some articles.
- Drawing on editing workshops held at the Convention, the Collegian's representatives will return to the Collegian and present the knowledge in editing they have acquired to all of the Head and Assistant Editors at the Collegian.
- They will build on existing principles for editing articles from different sections, and form a clear consensus on how to determine the suitability of an article. For example, to be suitable for publication, an article for the Arts section will:
    - Have at least four sources, preferably people;
    - Be concise, but describe the significance of the topic to wider society;
    - Keep details that connect the topic to wider society short, but well-connected to the main topic itself;
    - Refer to sensitive topics - race, religion, sexuality, gender or economic status - in a manner that does not oversimplify people of a certain demographic; and
    - Refer to more than one perspective that gives a well-rounded picture of the topic at hand.
- The results of the more rigorous editing process will be that Assistant, Copy and Night editors from all four editorial sections will publish articles more smoothly, with less confusion over whether it is suitable for publication or not.

Proposed Success for Individual Members of the Collegian

We will also conduct professional development sessions for individual members of the Collegian - both those who attended the Convention and those who could not. The goals of these

professional development sessions will be to ensure that all members of the Collegian are aware of their journalistic rights and responsibilities. All members of the Collegian, regardless of whether they attended the Convention or not, can take part. Those who did attend the Convention will focus on maintaining their networks, while the members who did not attend the Convention will be able to develop new professional networks of their own.

Professional development sessions for individual members of the Collegian

- We will arrange follow-up meetings with people involved with the Convention, including fellow student journalists, student media advisors and law specialists who spoke at the Convention, especially those with particularly unique perspectives.
- We will connect members of the Collegian who were not in attendance at the Convention with the people who were directly involved with the Convention.
- The goals of these follow-up meetings is for both parties to inquire with each other about their short- and long-term professional goals in journalism, including:
    - What issues they want to discuss, or which communities they want to raise awareness of, in the near future;
    - What kind of journalism they might want to pursue beyond the Collegian; and
    - How they think journalism, especially student journalism, can be supported.
- The end goals of these career development meetings are to solidify the Collegian members' writing and critical thinking skills whilst also demonstrating how they can demonstrate journalistic independence and inquiry whilst writing for any publication.

Description of Available Personnel

Although the Spring National College Media Convention is an excellent professional development opportunity for all members of the Collegian, we can only select three members to attend the Convention on behalf of the publication. We have selected the three following members, who represent different sections of the Collegian and can approach the various talks and workshops with different perspectives. We are confident that these three members will represent the other members of the Collegian effectively.

Qualifications of Available Personnel

Alexandra Hill, Head News Editor

Senior journalism major Alexandra Hill is currently the Head News Editor at the Collegian. Having been a member of the Collegian since her freshman year, she was promoted to Assistant News Editor in her junior year and then subsequently to Head News Editor in her senior year ("Alexandra Hill - Massachusetts Daily Collegian"). One vital reason Hill is qualified to represent the Collegian at the Convention is because she attended MediaFest '25 in Washington, DC in October 2025. Therefore, she is well qualified to understand the events at the Convention in March, and can not only form networks with other attendees but also help non-attendees form connections with resources from the Convention.

Hill has extensive experience covering news events both at the University of Massachusetts and in its surrounding areas. She was a key contributor to the Election Special Issue of 2024, during the presidential election. Her frequent coverage of on-campus protests, particularly social justice protests, gives her a good knowledge of how to address turbulent events. In addition, she was in charge of handling the coverage of the Olympia Place fire in November 2025, which she began covering since shortly after the fire broke out on the night of Friday, November 7. Hill's expertise in presenting timely coverage to a community audience equips her with suitable background knowledge for the workshops at the Convention.

Daniel Estrin, Head Opinion Editor

Sophomore communications major Daniel Estrin is currently the Head Opinion Editor at the Collegian. He has been a member of the Collegian since his freshman year ("Daniel Estrin - Massachusetts Daily Collegian"). With his first article having been an opinion piece on how the dining halls at the University needed more gluten-free options - based on his own experience with celiac disease - Estrin has established himself since the early days of his time at the Collegian. In the second semester of his freshman year, he became the youngest Assistant Opinion Editor, and in his sophomore year, he became the youngest Head section editor upon taking charge of the Opinion section.

Estrin attended the 2025 Georges Conference on College Journalism at Harvard University in Cambridge, Massachusetts ("2025 Georges Conference on College Journalism"). Attending a conference aimed directly at student journalists, in a scholastic setting, has given

him the skills to network with other attendees, understand the discussion topics effectively and present the topics to the rest of the Collegian upon his return. Further, Estrin has written articles for other sections, including News and Arts. His understanding of what criteria different articles require to be of a high standard of writing will allow him to contribute to the proposed process of streamlining the edits performed on the articles.

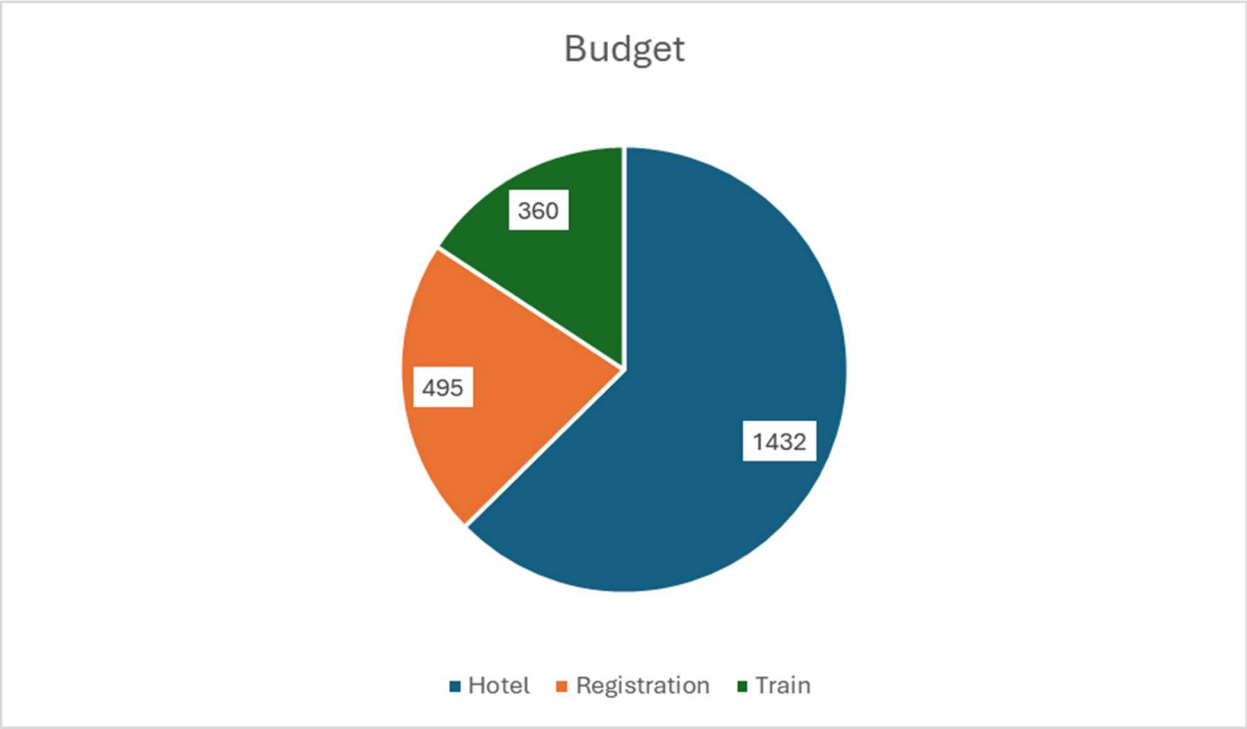
Paige Hanson, Assistant Arts Editor

Senior journalism major Paige Hanson is currently an Assistant Arts Editor at the Massachusetts Daily Collegian. She has been a member of the Collegian since her freshman year. In her sophomore year, she became an Assistant Social Media Editor, and in her junior year, she took on the role of Assistant Arts Editor as well ("Paige Hanson - Massachusetts Daily Collegian"). Hanson specializes in writing artist profiles of local bands including student bands, and has also interviewed the band Wheatus, best known for their single "Teenage Dirtbag."

Hanson is well-equipped to represent the Collegian at the Convention because of her knowledge in covering local musical acts, a key part of Amherst's cultural scene. She can raise awareness of local creative initiatives that might otherwise be overlooked by mainstream news and entertainment coverage. While she has written the majority of her articles for the Arts section, she has written a number of articles for the News section as well. Therefore, her knowledge of writing different articles for different genres will benefit her when we carry out the revised editing processes that we have proposed.

Budget

This proposal requests a grant of $2,287 dollars in total, which will cover the registration funds for the Collegian to enter into the Spring National College Media Convention, as well as train tickets and hotel accommodations in New York.



Allocation of budget

As of December 15, 2025, the nightly rate for one night at the New York Marriott Marquis hotel, where the Convention will be held, is $309. For three people to stay at the hotel for four nights, from March 3 to March 6 (the day before the Convention starts to the day before it ends) will cost **$1,432** including taxes ("Marriott Marquis New York"); that expense will take up the majority of the grant. The "early-bird" registration fee, to be paid before Friday, Jan. 30,

2026, is $165 per student; as three people will be registering to attend, the total registration costs will be **$495**.

While the closest Amtrak station to the University is Union Station, Northampton, while the closest Amtrak station to the Marriott Marquis is New York Penn Station. Traveling on the Amtrak's *Vermonter* line will save attendees time, as the journey itself is 4 hours and 24 minutes long, and they will not need to wait for extended periods of time in the airport. A round-trip ticket from Northampton to New York City costs $120 ("Amtrak"); for three people, that will cost **$360**.

Summary

Benefits to the Contracting Agent

The Massachusetts Daily Collegian is closely affiliated with the University's Journalism Department, who empowers students to further their journalistic education by helping them improve their writing and editing skills and educating them on journalistic freedom and independence. Providing the Collegian with a grant to attend the Spring National College Media Convention will allow aspiring journalists to hone their craft and learn more about their rights on the job, which is a shared goal between both the Collegian and the Journalism Department.

Objectives of the Grant

1. To enable three members of the Massachusetts Daily Collegian to register for the Spring National College Media Convention, organized by the College Media Association; and to enable them to travel to New York City, where the Convention is held, by train; and to stay at the New York Marriott Marquis hotel during the Convention;
2. To present the three members of the Collegian as representatives of independent student journalism, empowering other student journalists at the University of Massachusetts to be aware of and exercise their journalistic rights; and
3. To transfer knowledge gained from the conference to the Collegian in order to streamline its editing processes and develop professional connections for all of its members.

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Image credits

Cover images.

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College Media Asssociation logo – courtesy of the College Media Association's website

Alexandra Hill (14) – courtesy of the Massachusetts Daily Collegian

Daniel Estrin (15) – courtesy of the Massachusetts Daily Collegian

Paige Hanson (16) – courtesy of the Massachusetts Daily Collegian

Budget pie chart (17) – courtesy of Kalana Amarasekara